

Psalms 115

Not Unto Us, O Lord

Not unto us, O Lord, not unto us, but unto thy name give glory
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Not unto us, O LORD, not unto us, but unto thy name give glory, for thy mercy, and for thy truth's sake.*
- 2 *Wherefore should the heathen say, Where is now their God?*
- 3 *But our God is in the heavens: he hath done whatsoever he hath pleased.*
- 4 *Their idols are silver and gold, the work of men's hands.*
- 5 *They have mouths, but they speak not: eyes have they, but they see not:*
- 6 *They have ears, but they hear not: noses have they, but they smell not:*
- 7 *They have hands, but they handle not: feet have they, but they walk not: neither speak they through their throat.*
- 8 *They that make them are like unto them; so is every one that trusteth in them.*
- 9 *O Israel, trust thou in the LORD: he is their help and their shield.*
- 10 *O house of Aaron, trust in the LORD: he is their help and their shield.*
- 11 *Ye that fear the LORD, trust in the LORD: he is their help and their shield.*
- 12 *The LORD hath been mindful of us: he will bless us; he will bless the house of Israel; he will bless the house of Aaron.*
- 13 *He will bless them that fear the LORD, both small and great.*
- 14 *The LORD shall increase you more and more, you and your children.*
- 15 *Ye are blessed of the LORD which made heaven and earth.*
- 16 *The heaven, even the heavens, are the LORD'S: but the earth hath he given to the children of men.*
- 17 *The dead praise not the LORD, neither any that go down into silence.*
- 18 *But we will bless the LORD from this time forth and for evermore. Praise the LORD.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 115 opens by deflecting glory entirely away from the psalmist and toward God's name alone, then contrasts the living, active God of Israel with lifeless idols that have every human feature yet can do nothing with them—before closing in threefold, escalating exhortation to trust and a confident blessing on the living and the dead alike. Henry treats the idol satire as deliberately physical and almost comic: mouths that cannot speak, eyes that cannot see, precisely to expose how absurd it is to trust in something less capable than the person who made it.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The opening plea insists that glory belongs entirely to God's name, for His mercy and truth's sake, not to Israel—forestalling any accusation from the nations asking where Israel's God has gone. The answer given is simple and total: our God is in the heavens, doing whatever He pleases, unconstrained by circumstance or scorn.

Verse 4-8

Idols are described with pointed, almost satirical precision: silver and gold, made by human hands, with mouths that cannot speak, eyes that cannot see, ears that cannot hear, noses that cannot smell, hands that cannot handle, feet that cannot walk. The conclusion is blunt—those who make and trust them become just as lifeless and unresponsive as the idols themselves.

Verse 9-11

A threefold call to trust follows, addressed successively to Israel, the house of Aaron, and all who fear the Lord, each closing with the same refrain: He is their help and their shield. Repetition itself becomes the argument—trust is urged from every angle of the community.

Verse 12-15

God's mindfulness of His people is affirmed as blessing, extending to the house of Israel, the house of Aaron, and all who fear Him, both small and great, with increase promised to them and their children. The blessing is traced to its ultimate source: the Lord who made heaven and earth.

Verse 16-18

A final contrast closes the psalm: the heavens belong to the Lord, but the earth has been given to humanity; the dead do not praise Him, nor those who go down into silence, but we—the living—will bless the Lord now and forevermore, ending on the same note it began: praise the Lord.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Idols possess every human feature yet remain entirely inert, and the psalm's blunt observation—that those who trust them become just as unresponsive—warns that trust is always formative, shaping the truster into the likeness of whatever is trusted. Genuine glory belongs to God alone, not to human reputation, and the fitting response to a living, active God is active, present-tense praise while there is still breath to give it.

Application for life today.

Examine what modern 'idols'—things with impressive features but no real capacity to help—you have been quietly trusting, and let this psalm's blunt satire expose their actual inertness. Notice the threefold repetition in verses 9–11 and let it press the question personally: whichever group you belong to, the refrain 'he is their help and their shield' is addressed directly to you. Let verse 17's observation that the dead do not praise God sharpen your sense that praise now, while you are living, is a specific opportunity rather than something to postpone.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What present-day 'idol'—something with impressive features but no actual capacity to help—has this psalm's blunt description (vv. 4–7) exposed as quietly trusted by you?

2. The refrain 'he is their help and their shield' (vv. 9–11) is repeated three times for emphasis—what would it mean to actually believe it applies to you specifically today?

3. How does verse 17's reminder that praise belongs to the living, not the silent dead, change how urgently you treat today's opportunity to bless God?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).